



Date mussel on a coral reef in the Red Sea

DATE MUSSEL

Many different clams live on coral reefs. This date mussel makes its home by producing chemicals to wear a hole in the hard coral. Like most clams, the mussel feeds by collecting food particles from water passing through its gills.

Narrow snout probes for sponges and other animals that grow on rocks

Special glands in skin make slug taste bad to deter predators

Flat, slimy foot enables slug to crawl over slippery seaweed

Adult

GROWING UP

Angelfish are common inhabitants of coral reefs. The young emperor angelfish looks quite different from the adult, possibly because its colors protect it better. Once the adults pair up, they establish a territory on the reef where they can feed. Their colors and patterns help other emperors to recognize them, so they can see their patch of the reef is occupied.

Juvenile

Ring patterns may draw predator away from juvenile's more vulnerable head

Bright colors help attract a mate

Plain yellow caudal (tail) fin

Adult emperor angelfish's colors and patterns act as signals to other angelfish



Crown-of-thorns starfish eating coral

NOTORIOUS STARFISH

The crown-of-thorns starfish devours the soft parts of a gorgonian coral. Like many other starfish, it feeds by turning its stomach inside out, making enzymes to digest its prey. Plagues of these starfish attacked Australia's Great Barrier Reef in the 1960s and 1970s, killing large numbers of corals.

Tentacles around mouth used for feeding

Tentacles can be pulled back inside body for protection

Tough skin

One of five rows of tube-feet helps sea cucumber crawl

Lettuce slug breathes through its skin, which looks like the leaf of a plant

COLORFUL CUCUMBER

One of the most colorful kinds of sea cucumber lives on or close to reefs in the Indo-Pacific region. Sea cucumbers are echinoderms (pp.18-19), like starfish, sea urchins, and sea lilies. The sea cucumber puts out its sticky tentacles to feed on small particles of food. Once the food has stuck onto the mucus on the tentacle, it is placed inside the mouth and the food removed.

Special fat tentacles for smelling food